

GALLANT IAS ACADEMY
PRELIMS CUM MAINS BATCH 2027
ANCIENT INDIA
MODULE 1

PREHISTORIC AGE TIMELINE & SUMMARY

PREHISTORIC AGE: TIMELINE

<u>Prehistoric Age</u>	<u>Time Period (approx.)</u>	<u>Key Features</u>
<u>Palaeolithic Age</u>	2 million BCE - 10,000 BCE	Earliest stone tools, hunter-gatherers, caves & shelters
<u>Mesolithic Age</u>	10,000 BCE - 6000 BCE	Microliths, semi-nomadic life, beginning of domestication
<u>Neolithic Age</u>	7000 BCE - 1000 BCE	Farming, domestication, polished tools, village settlements
<u>Chalcolithic Age</u>	3000 BCE - 700 BCE (regional variations)	Use of copper + stone tools, pottery, rural settlements
<u>Iron Age</u>	1000 BCE onward	Iron tools, agriculture, Vedic culture, states emerge

PALAEOLITHIC PERIOD SUBDIVISION

<u>Period</u>	<u>Time Frame</u>	<u>Tools & Culture</u>
<u>Lower</u>	2 million - 100,000 BCE	Hand axes, cleavers
<u>Middle</u>	100,000 - 40,000 BCE	Flakes, scrapers
<u>Upper</u>	40,000 - 10,000 BCE	Blades, burins, beginnings of art

MESOLITHIC AGE

<u>Feature</u>	<u>Detail</u>
<u>Time Period</u>	10,000 - 6000 BCE (some sites till 2000 BCE)
<u>Tools</u>	<u>Microlithic tools</u>
<u>Other Features</u>	Early domestication, rock art

NEOLITHIC AGE

<u>Region</u>	<u>Period / Site</u>	<u>Site</u>
<u>Earliest Site</u>	<u>Mehrgarh (7000 BCE)</u>	Baluchistan - earliest farming village
<u>South India</u>	Neolithic begins ~3000 BCE	
<u>Eastern India</u>	Neolithic appears ~2000 BCE	

CHALCOLITHIC AGE: REGIONAL CULTURES

<u>Culture</u>	<u>Region</u>	<u>Time Period</u>
<u>Ahar-Banas Culture</u>	Rajasthan	2500 - 1500 BCE
<u>Malwa Culture</u>	Madhya Pradesh	1800 - 1400 BCE
<u>Jorwe Culture</u>	Maharashtra	1400 - 700 BCE
<u>OCP Culture</u>	Ganga-Yamuna Doab	~2000 - 1000 BCE

PREHISTORIC INDIA

Prehistory refers to the period before written records. It is reconstructed mainly through stone tools, pottery, bones, burials, habitations and rock paintings.

Broad Sequence

Palaeolithic → Mesolithic → Neolithic → Chalcolithic. These stages were based on changes in technology, food production and settlement patterns; their dates varied regionally and often overlapped.

Palaeolithic Age

Beginning around 2 million years ago, it was marked by hunting-gathering and stone tools such as **choppers, handaxes, cleavers, scrapers and blades.** Attirampakkam and Isampur preserve very early evidence. People lived in **caves, rock shelters and temporary open-air camps** near water, forests, animals and tool-making stones. **Bhimbetka** is the best-known rock-shelter site.

Mesolithic Age

Beginning approximately 10,000 years ago, it was characterised by tiny tools called **microliths, bows and arrows, fishing and hunting of smaller animals.**

Rock art: Paintings depict hunting, dancing, music, animals and community activities. Bhimbetka contains paintings belonging to the **Upper Palaeolithic, Mesolithic and Chalcolithic phases.**

Neolithic Revolution

Humans gradually shifted from food gathering to food production through **agriculture and animal domestication.** Permanent villages, polished stone tools, pottery and storage developed. **Mehrgarh**, dating from about 7000 BCE, was an early farming village. Other important sites include **Burzahom, Chirand, Daojali Hading, Koldihwa and Hallur.**

Chalcolithic Age

Communities used **copper alongside stone tools.** Agriculture, animal husbandry, pottery, metallurgy, crafts and regional trade expanded. Important cultures included **Ahar, Malwa and Jorwe.**

Historical Significance

Prehistoric developments laid the foundations of Indian civilisation - **settled agriculture, village communities, craft specialisation, exchange networks and eventually urbanisation.**

Important Neolithic Sites

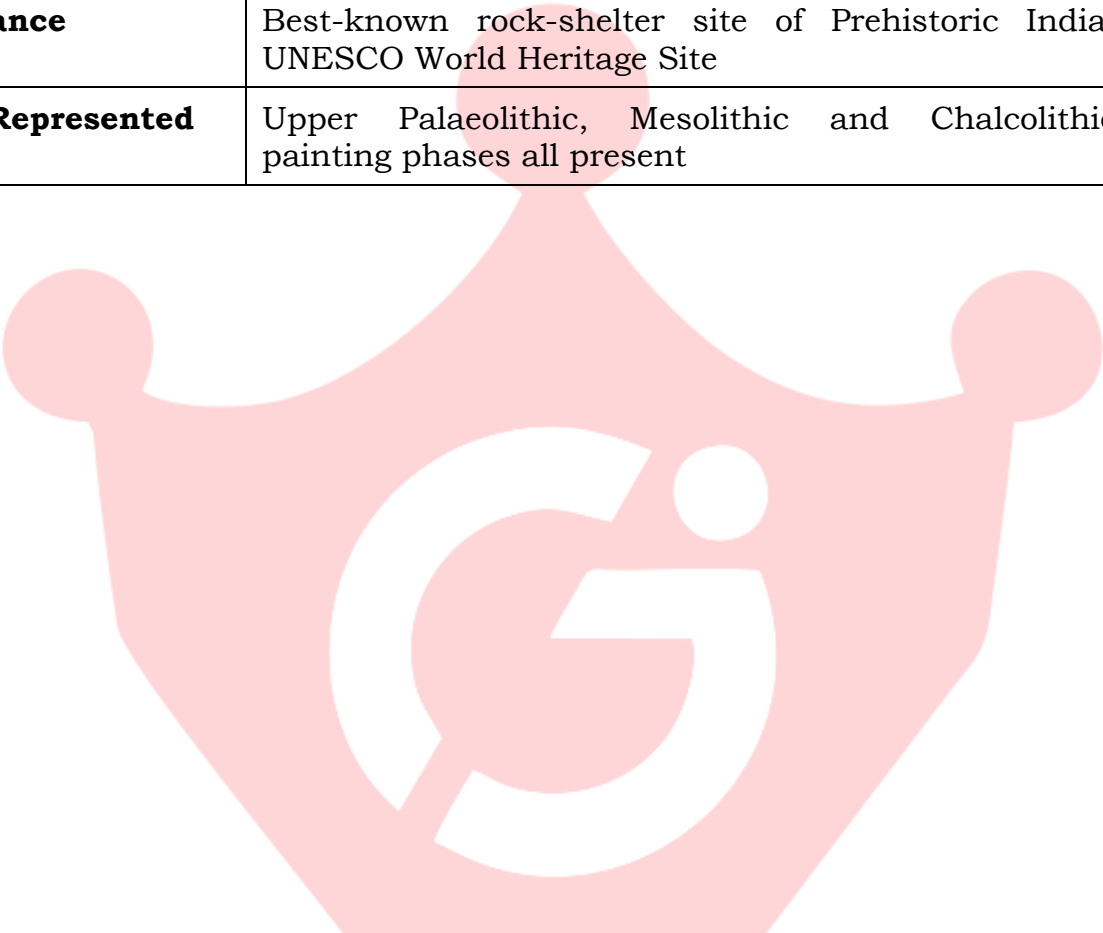
<u>Site</u>	<u>Location</u>	<u>Significance</u>
<u>Mehrgarh</u>	Baluchistan	Earliest farming village, ~7000 BCE
<u>Burzahom</u>	Kashmir	Pit dwellings, bone tools, megalithic burials
<u>Chirand</u>	Bihar	Bone tools, pottery, Eastern Neolithic
<u>Daojali Hading</u>	Assam	North-Eastern Neolithic culture
<u>Koldihwa</u>	Uttar Pradesh	Early evidence of rice cultivation
<u>Hallur</u>	Karnataka	Neolithic-Chalcolithic site, South India

HOW AESTHETIC SENSE IS REFLECTED IN PREHISTORIC PAINTINGS

	Aesthetic Quality	Evidence from Prehistoric Paintings
1	Sense of Realism and Observation	Animals drawn with keen observation. At Bhimbetka, animals like bison, deer and elephants are shown in a naturalistic style, capturing their muscle structure and motion.
2	Use of Color and Technique	Natural pigments used: red ochre, white, green, yellow, charcoal. Red is used for hunting scenes, white for rituals. Shading, dots, lines and brush-like strokes indicate deliberate technique.
3	Composition and Harmony	Paintings arranged in storyboard format indicate narrative thinking.
4	Symbolism and Abstract Thinking	Certain signs, human-animal hybrids and geometric patterns suggest symbolic or ritualistic meaning. Aesthetics was not just for beauty but for spiritual, magical or communal purposes.
5	Variety of Themes	Not limited to hunting: includes dancing, rituals, daily life and social interactions. Bhimbetka caves show a row of dancers, reflecting joy and group activity - an aesthetic appreciation of life itself.
6	Attention to Detail	Feathers, horns, tails, weapons - all drawn with precision. Indicates artistic skill and mental visualization.
7	Innovation and Continuity	Changes in style and themes over time reflect evolving artistic trends. Mesolithic paintings show smaller figures and more dynamism, indicating experimentation.

BHIMBETKA ROCK SHELTERS

<u>Feature</u>	<u>Detail</u>
Total Rock Shelters	Over 500 rock shelters
Time Span	Dating from Upper Paleolithic to Medieval
Painting Layers	Display multi-layered paintings
Color Durability	Colors still visible after 10,000+ years - testimony to technical knowledge and aesthetic durability
Significance	Best-known rock-shelter site of Prehistoric India; UNESCO World Heritage Site
Phases Represented	Upper Palaeolithic, Mesolithic and Chalcolithic painting phases all present



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